BHARATVERSE

PRITHVI MEETS JAL

CHAPTER 1

DRY EDGE

THE WATER WAS THIN HERE.

THAT WAS THE FIRST THING ZARA NOTICED, AND IT FRIGHTENED HER MORE THAN SHE WOULD HAVE ADMITTED TO ANYONE.

THE CREEK MOUTH AT KANDLA SMELLED OF DIESEL AND BRINE, AND SHE COULD FEEL THE SEA AT HER BACK, VAST AND PATIENT, THE WAY YOU FEEL A WALL BEHIND YOU.

BUT AHEAD, UP THE NARROWING TIDAL CHANNEL, THE WATER THINNED.

BRACKISH. TIRED.

A FEW CENTIMETRES OF SILTY TIDE OVER MUD, RUNNING OUT INTO A WHITE, SHIMMERING NOTHING, AND BEYOND THAT A DRYNESS SHE COULD FEEL THE WAY A SWIMMER FEELS THE END OF THE POOL.

SHE HAD NEVER BEEN THIS FAR FROM DEEP WATER IN HER LIFE.

SHE HAD COME BECAUSE OF THE SHUDDER.

A FORTNIGHT AGO, AT SEVEN MINUTES PAST TWO IN THE MORNING, THE BAY OF BENGAL HAD FLINCHED.

SHE HAD BEEN LYING AWAKE IN THE SEALED CHAMBER UNDER THE FORT WHEN THE WHOLE BODY OF THE WATER RANG ONCE, LIKE A STRUCK STRING, FROM SOMEWHERE FAR TO THE WEST.

ONE OF THE LONG DARK FLUID SEAMS THAT RAN BENEETH THE SUBCONTINENT HAD CARRIED THE TREMOR FROM A PLACE SHE COULD NOT SEE.

SHE HAD LAIN THERE WITH HER PALMS FLAT ON THE STONE AND THOUGHT—

SOMETHING JUST WOKE UP.

SHE HAD THOUGHT NOTHING MORE OF IT UNTIL ARJUN MEHTA SAID THE WORD FIVE.

FIVE.

ON THE FIFTH DAY AFTER THE BAY, SHE TOLD RAJAN TO BOOK HER A BERTH ON A FEEDER FROM CHENNAI TO KANDLA, ON A MANIFEST THEY HAD NOT USED IN SIX YEARS.

BOSS, THAT'S THE GUJARAT BORDER.

I KNOW WHERE IT IS.

IT'S THE DRY SIDE.

I KNOW THAT TOO.

I'LL BE BACK IN A WEEK.

THE OLD THIEVES' ROUTE HAD NOT CHANGED.

A DINGHY OFF THE FEEDER AT TWO IN THE MORNING, A MILE OF MANGROVE, AND THEN THE CREEK THE LOCALS CALLED CHOR KHADI, WHICH SHE HAD RUN AT NINETEEN WITH A HOLD FULL OF ELECTRONICS AND A FORGED MANIFEST.

IT HAD BEEN THE FIRST TIME SHE EVER FELT SHE OWNED A PIECE OF THE WORLD.

SHE WADED THE LAST HUNDRED METRES THROUGH KNEE-DEEP TIDE WITH HER BOOTS IN HER HAND AND THE SALT CRUST CRACKING UNDER HER FEET.

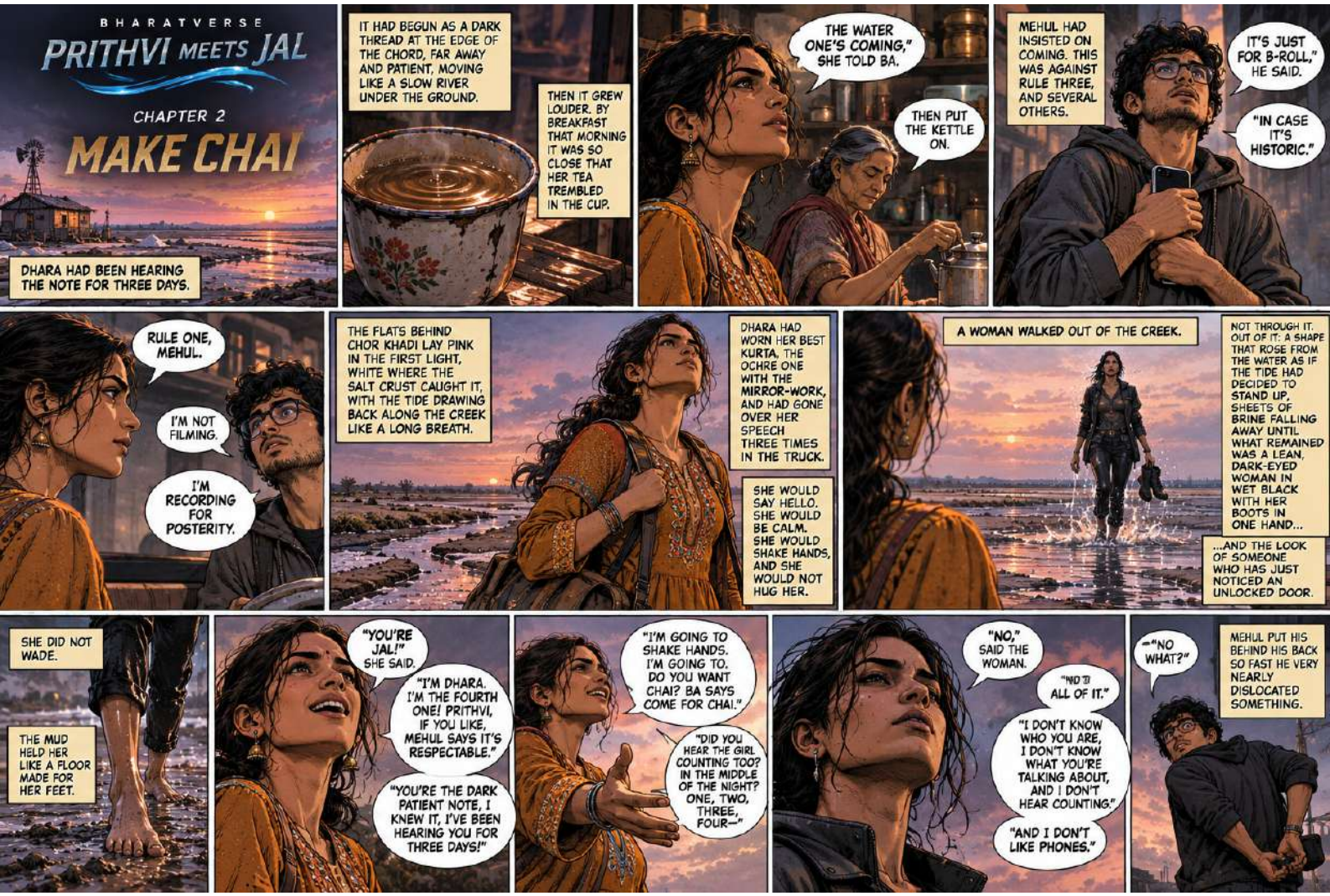
AND THEN SHE FELT IT.

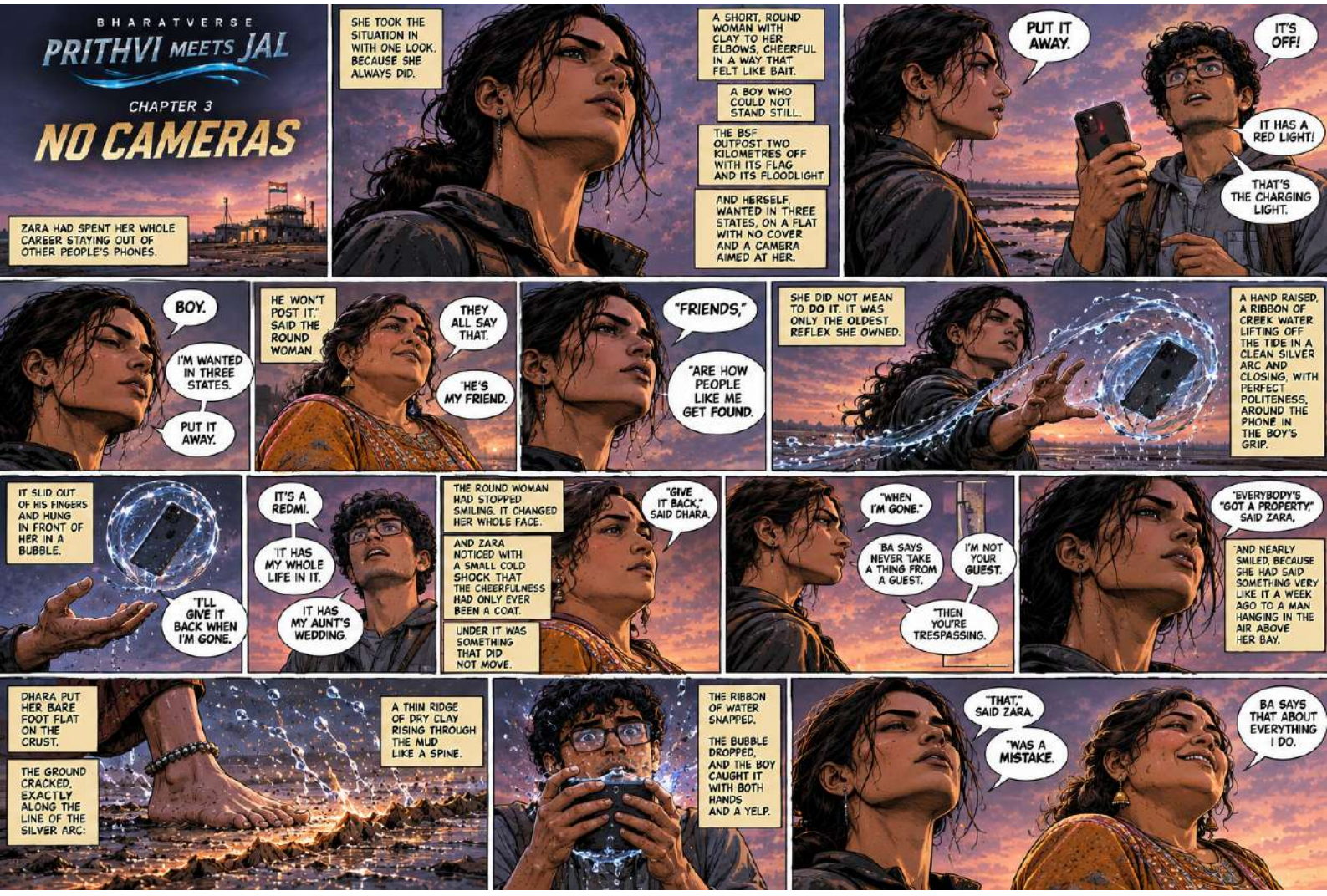
AHEAD OF HER, ON THE FLATS, SOMETHING THAT WAS NOT WATER.

A WEIGHT ON THE GROUND, LISTENING. NOT A PERSON, EXACTLY. SOMETHING LIKE A PERSON THAT THE EARTH LEANED TOWARD, THE WAY THE BAY HAD LEANED TOWARD ARJUN.

SHE STOPPED WALKING.

"ALRIGHT," SHE SAID, VERY SOFTLY, TO NOBODY. "FINE."


BHARATVERSE
PRITHVI MEETS JAL
CHAPTER 2
MAKE CHAI
DHARA HAD BEEN HEARING THE NOTE FOR THREE DAYS.
IT HAD BEGUN AS A DARK THREAD AT THE EDGE OF THE CHORD, FAR AWAY AND PATIENT, MOVING LIKE A SLOW RIVER UNDER THE GROUND.
THEN IT GREW LOUDER. BY BREAKFAST THAT MORNING IT WAS SO CLOSE THAT HER TEA TREMBLED IN THE CUP.
THE WATER ONE'S COMING," SHE TOLD BA.
THEN PUT THE KETTLE ON.
MEHUL HAD INSISTED ON COMING. THIS WAS AGAINST RULE THREE, AND SEVERAL OTHERS.
IT'S JUST FOR B-ROLL," HE SAID.
"IN CASE IT'S HISTORIC."
RULE ONE, MEHUL.
I'M NOT FILMING.
I'M RECORDING FOR POSTERITY.
THE FLATS BEHIND CHOR KHADI LAY PINK IN THE FIRST LIGHT, WHITE WHERE THE SALT CRUST CAUGHT IT, WITH THE TIDE DRAWING BACK ALONG THE CREEK LIKE A LONG BREATH.
DHARA HAD WORN HER BEST KURTA, THE OCHRE ONE WITH THE MIRROR-WORK, AND HAD GONE OVER HER SPEECH THREE TIMES IN THE TRUCK.
SHE WOULD SAY HELLO. SHE WOULD BE CALM. SHE WOULD SHAKE HANDS, AND SHE WOULD NOT HUG HER.
A WOMAN WALKED OUT OF THE CREEK.
NOT THROUGH IT. OUT OF IT: A SHAPE THAT ROSE FROM THE WATER AS IF THE TIDE HAD DECIDED TO STAND UP, SHEETS OF BRINE FALLING AWAY UNTIL WHAT REMAINED WAS A LEAN, DARK-EYED WOMAN IN WET BLACK WITH HER BOOTS IN ONE HAND...
...AND THE LOOK OF SOMEONE WHO HAS JUST NOTICED AN UNLOCKED DOOR.
SHE DID NOT WADE.
THE MUD HELD HER LIKE A FLOOR MADE FOR HER FEET.
"YOU'RE JAL!" SHE SAID.
"I'M DHARA. I'M THE FOURTH ONE! PRITHVI, IF YOU LIKE, MEHUL SAYS IT'S RESPECTABLE."
"YOU'RE THE DARK PATIENT NOTE, I KNEW IT, I'VE BEEN HEARING YOU FOR THREE DAYS!"
"I'M GOING TO SHAKE HANDS. I'M GOING TO. DO YOU WANT CHAI? BA SAYS COME FOR CHAI."
"DID YOU HEAR THE GIRL COUNTING TOO? IN THE MIDDLE OF THE NIGHT? ONE, TWO, THREE, FOUR—"
"NO," SAID THE WOMAN.
"NO TO ALL OF IT."
"I DON'T KNOW WHO YOU ARE, I DON'T KNOW WHAT YOU'RE TALKING ABOUT, AND I DON'T HEAR COUNTING."
"AND I DON'T LIKE PHONES."
—"NO WHAT?"
MEHUL PUT HIS BEHIND HIS BACK SO FAST HE VERY NEARLY DISLOCATED SOMETHING.


BHARATVERSE
PRITHVI MEETS JAL
CHAPTER 3
NO CAMERAS
ZARA HAD SPENT HER WHOLE CAREER STAYING OUT OF OTHER PEOPLE'S PHONES.
SHE TOOK THE SITUATION IN WITH ONE LOOK, BECAUSE SHE ALWAYS DID.
A SHORT, ROUND WOMAN WITH CLAY TO HER ELBOWS, CHEERFUL IN A WAY THAT FELT LIKE BAIT.
A BOY WHO COULD NOT STAND STILL.
THE BSF OUTPOST TWO KILOMETRES OFF WITH ITS FLAG AND ITS FLOODLIGHT.
AND HERSELF, WANTED IN THREE STATES, ON A FLAT WITH NO COVER AND A CAMERA AIMED AT HER.
PUT IT AWAY.
IT'S OFF!
IT HAS A RED LIGHT!
THAT'S THE CHARGING LIGHT.
BOY.
I'M WANTED IN THREE STATES.
PUT IT AWAY.
HE WON'T POST IT," SAID THE ROUND WOMAN.
THEY ALL SAY THAT.
"HE'S MY FRIEND.
"FRIENDS,"
"ARE HOW PEOPLE LIKE ME GET FOUND.
SHE DID NOT MEAN TO DO IT. IT WAS ONLY THE OLDEST REFLEX SHE OWNED.
A HAND RAISED, A RIBBON OF CREEK WATER LIFTING OFF THE TIDE IN A CLEAN SILVER ARC AND CLOSING, WITH PERFECT POLITENESS, AROUND THE PHONE IN THE BOY'S GRIP.
IT SLID OUT OF HIS FINGERS AND HUNG IN FRONT OF HER IN A BUBBLE.
"I'LL GIVE IT BACK WHEN I'M GONE.
IT'S A REDMI.
"IT HAS MY WHOLE LIFE IN IT.
IT HAS MY AUNT'S WEDDING.
THE ROUND WOMAN HAD STOPPED SMILING. IT CHANGED HER WHOLE FACE.
AND ZARA NOTICED WITH A SMALL COLD SHOCK THAT THE CHEERFULNESS HAD ONLY EVER BEEN A COAT.
UNDER IT WAS SOMETHING THAT DID NOT MOVE.
"GIVE IT BACK," SAID DHARA.
"WHEN I'M GONE."
BA SAYS NEVER TAKE A THING FROM A GUEST.
I'M NOT YOUR GUEST.
"THEN YOU'RE TRESPASSING.
"EVERYBODY'S "GOT A PROPERTY," SAID ZARA,
"AND NEARLY SMILED, BECAUSE SHE HAD SAID SOMETHING VERY LIKE IT A WEEK AGO TO A MAN HANGING IN THE AIR ABOVE HER BAY.
DHARA PUT HER BARE FOOT FLAT ON THE CRUST.
THE GROUND CRACKED, EXACTLY ALONG THE LINE OF THE SILVER ARC:
A THIN RIDGE OF DRY CLAY RISING THROUGH THE MUD LIKE A SPINE.
THE RIBBON OF WATER SNAPPED.
THE BUBBLE DROPPED, AND THE BOY CAUGHT IT WITH BOTH HANDS AND A YELP.
"THAT," SAID ZARA.
"WAS A MISTAKE.
BA SAYS THAT ABOUT EVERYTHING I DO.

BHARATVERSE

PRITHVI MEETS JAL

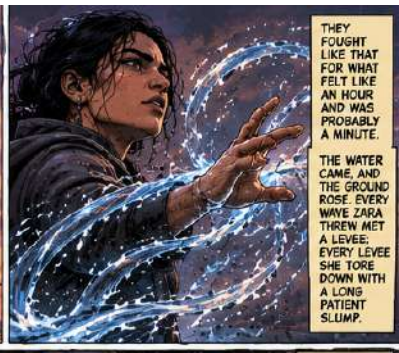
CHAPTER 4

SOUP AND STONE



















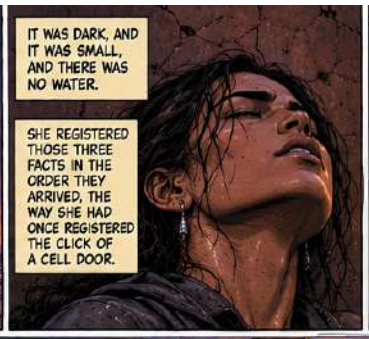









BHARATVERSE
PRITHVI MEETS JAL
CHAPTER 5
UNDER THE DOME


IT WAS DARK, AND IT WAS SMALL, AND THERE WAS NO WATER.
SHE REGISTERED THOSE THREE FACTS IN THE ORDER THEY ARRIVED, THE WAY SHE HAD ONCE REGISTERED THE CLICK OF A CELL DOOR.


THE CLAY WAS WARM AND DRY ON EVERY SIDE. THERE WAS NO CREEK IN IT, NO TIDE, NO THREAD OF MOISTURE SHE COULD PULL ON.
SHE PUT BOTH HANDS AGAINST THE WALL AND PUSHED, AND THE WALL DID NOT MOVE.


THEN SHE COULD NOT HEAR HER OWN BREATHING, ONLY THE BLOOD IN HER EARS, AND THE SOUND OF A LOCK SHE HAD NOT HEARD IN SIX YEARS.
PUZHAL CENTRAL PRISON. TWENTY-SIX MONTHS. A CEILING SHE COULD TOUCH WITH HER FINGERTIPS.


SHE DID NOT SCREAM. SHE HAD NOT SCREAMED IN THERE EITHER.


SHE DID WHAT SHE HAD DONE THEN: WENT VERY STILL AND VERY SMALL AND WAITED FOR IT TO BE OVER.
BUT THE THING UNDER HER RIBS THAT WAS NOT HER, THAT WAS THE BAY, THIRTY METRES OF COLD BLACK WATER PRESSING IN FROM EVERY SIDE, WOULD NOT WAIT.


SHE LET GO OF EVERYTHING.
EVERY DROP SHE HAD DRAWN FROM THE CREEK BED, FROM THE AIR, FROM THE SWEAT ON HER OWN SKIN, EVERY THREAD SHE HAD STRETCHED ACROSS THIRTY METRES OF DRY CLAY, ALL OF IT WENT OFF AT ONCE IN A SINGLE OUTWARD BLAST.
THE BELL EXPLODED IN A WASH OF GREY WATER AND SHATTERED POTTERY.


SHE CAME OUT ON HER KNEES IN THE MUD, HANDS OVER HER EARS, WITH SEA IN HER MOUTH.
A SHORT ROUND WOMAN IN AN OCHRE KURTA STOOD THREE PACES AWAY WITH HER HANDS HELD OPEN AND NO WALL BETWEEN THEM AT ALL.


"I'M SORRY," SHE SAID.
"I'M SO SORRY. I DIDN'T KNOW."
"I PUT A LID ON A POT. THAT'S ALL I THOUGHT. I PUT A LID ON A POT."


"YOU DON'T APOLOGISE DURING A FIGHT," SHE SAID HOARSELY.


"I'M NOT FIGHTING ANY MORE."
"THEN YOU'VE LOST."
"BA SAYS WHEN A POT CRACKS IN THE KILN, IT'S BECAUSE YOU HURRIED IT."
"I HURRIED."


IT WAS THE SECOND TIME IN A WEEK THAT SOMEONE HAD APOLOGISED IN THE MIDDLE OF ONE OF HER FIGHTS.
SHE WAS BEGINNING TO WONDER WHAT WAS WRONG WITH ALL OF THEM.


SHE STAYED ON HER KNEES IN THE MUD A LONG MOMENT, AND DHARA DID NOT MOVE, AND DID NOT TOUCH HER, AND DID NOT SAY ANYTHING ELSE.
IT WAS, ZARA WOULD LATER ADMIT TO A VERY SMALL AUDIENCE, THE SINGLE MOST USEFUL THING ANYONE COULD HAVE DONE.

BHARATVERSE

PRITHVI MEETS JAL

CHAPTER 6

SIX

CHOR KHADI LAY QUIET AROUND THEM. THE SUN HAD CLEARED THE HORIZON, AND THE FLATS HAD GONE FROM PINK TO WHITE.

THE SHATTERED CLAY LAY SCATTERED IN RED-ORANGE SHARDS, AND SOMEWHERE IN THE MIDDLE OF IT A VERY FRIGHTENED BOY WAS STILL HOLDING HIS PHONE WITH BOTH HANDS.

DHARA SAT ON A BROKEN PIECE OF DOME, FLEXING HER STIFF FINGERS. ZARA SAT ACROSS FROM HER WITH HER BOOTS BESIDE HER AND HER LIPS CRACKED, DRINKING FROM A FLASK.

NEITHER OF THEM WAS GOOD FOR ANOTHER ROUND.

"THAT," SAID MEHUL FAINTLY.

"WAS THE BEST CONTENT I'VE EVER NOT FILMED."

"I DELETED IT. EVERYTHING. IT'S ALL GONE. LOOK."

All media deleted

"FOUR SETS OF BOOTS," SHE SAID. "ON THE BIG DUNE TO THE EAST.

"IN STEP. THEY'VE BEEN THERE SINCE BEFORE YOU CAME OUT OF THE WATER."

ZARA'S OWN HAND WAS ALREADY IN THE CREEK.

"TWO IN THE WATER," SHE SAID. "FOUR ON THE DUNE."

FOUR ON THE DUNE.

TWO IN THE WATER.

"SIX."

"SIX," SAID BOTH OF THEM.

"FOUR, THEN SIX," SAID ZARA QUIETLY. "THAT'S HOW THEY CAME AT MY FORT. THEY'VE FOLLOWED ME."

"I LED THEM TO YOU."

"NO," DHARA SHOOK HER HEAD. "LOOK AT THE JEEP.

IT SAT AT THE FAR END OF THE FLAT, GREY AND DUSTY, WITH A TRIPOD ON ITS ROOF. ON THE CASE STRAPPED BESIDE IT, SMALL, STENCILLED IN WHITE, WAS A CIRCLE CROSSED BY A SINGLE LINE.

"IT'S BEEN THERE SINCE THE SCHOOL ROOF," SAID DHARA. "I THOUGHT THEY WERE FROM THE GOVERNMENT. "I THOUGHT THEY WERE NICE."

"THE FIRST TEAM'S CASES HAD THAT MARK."

"IS IT THE SAME PEOPLE?"

"I DON'T KNOW."

"I DO ARRANGEMENTS," SAID ZARA AT LAST. "I DON'T DO ALLIANCES. IF I GO IN YOUR HOUSE, I'M SEEN. IF I STAY OUT HERE, I'M SEEN."

"BA MAKES CHAI.

"THAT'S NOT AN ANSWER.

"IT'S THE ONLY ONE I'VE GOT."

"AND I KNOW A LADY FROM CHENNAI WHO NEEDS TWO HUNDRED DIYAS FOR A WEDDING."

"I HATE THIS."

"YOU HAVE A BETTER IDEA?

"NO."

BA WAS STANDING IN THE DOORWAY OF THE STUDIO WHEN BASANTI RATTLED INT THE YARD, A SMALL STERN WOMAN IN A PURPLE GHAGHRA WITHA LADLE IN HER HAND.

SHE LOOKED AT ZARA FOR THE COMING.

"YOU'RE WET."

"YES."

"SIT."

A GLASS WAS PUT IN FRONT OF HER. SHE DRANK, AND HER FACE DID SOMETHING COMPLICATED.

"IT'S VERY STRONG."

"IT'S THE STRONGEST LEGAL SUBSTANCE IN THE DISTRICT."

"MY MOTHER'S MOTHER SAID THAT WHEN THE GROUND TURNED OVER, SOMEONE WOULD COME OUT OF THE SEA," SAID BA. "I THOUGHT IN'WAS A STORY."

"I'M NOT PROPHECY."

"NOBODY ASKED YOU TO BE."

THROUGH THE WINDOW THE TWO OF THEM WATCHED THE DUNE. A WOMAN WITH HER PALM ON THE FLOOR AND A WOMAN WITH HER FINGERS IN A GLASS OF WATER, AND BETWEEN THEM THEY COULD COUNT EVERYTHING FOR A KILOMETRE IN EVERY DIRECTION.

"SIX," THEY COUNTED TOGETHER.

A SEVENTH, FAR AWAY IN THE NORTH, A THIN COLD VOICE AT THE EDGE OF THE CHORD, COUNTING. SOMETHING ELSE.

IN A ROOM WITH A DOOR THAT SAID PRIYA, A GIRL WHO HAD BEEN LISTENING FOR WEEKS FELT TWO NOTES COME TOGETHER IN THE CHORD.

Song 1 – Jal
Song 2 – Prithvi
→ Convergence
→ Watch: 6 + 1